logged in many thousands of flying hours, even offered to fly the machine to save the minister from the potential danger of flying with an inexperienced civilian pilot like myself and gestured to me to come out of the machine. I was sure about my competence in flying the machine I had made, and therefore shook my head in negation. Observing this wordless communication, Krishna Menon dismissed the insulting suggestion of the Group Captain with a laugh and signal ed to me to start the machine. He was very happy.

“You have demonstrated that the basic problems of hovercraft development are solved. Go for a more powerful prime mover and cal me for a second ride,” Krishna Menon told me. The skeptical Group Captain (now Air Marshal) Golay, later became a good friend of mine.

We completed the project ahead of schedule. We had a working hovercraft with us, moving on an air cushion of about 40mm with a load of 550kg, including the tare weight. Dr Mediratta was visibly pleased with the achievement. But by this time, Krishna Menon was out of office and could not take his promised second ride. In the new order, not many people shared his dream with regard to military applications of an indigenous hovercraft. In fact, even